was helping the war effort), and how certain I was that I would go back to research the instant I was discharged.

They then asked me if I would not be able to work at the Army's scientific labs in Chicago, or in chemical warfare, and I did my best to point out that they wouldn't suit me as well as theoretical or "pure" research.

Finally, one of them asked me why I had not tried out for officers' candidate school. I suggested that my eyes would not meet the required standards, but he said he thought that objection could be met. Was there any other reason?

This question, I knew, was the jackpot, win or lose. If I expressed

disdain for officer status, then I could stay in the Army for life, as far as they were concerned, and be a private every day of it. If I expressed enthusiasm for officer status, they would have me sign an application for officer training. Neither alternative was bearable and I had to find something that was neither disdain nor enthusiasm and I had to do it without perceptible pause.

I thought more rapidly than at any time since the case of Professor Thomas, 4V2 years before. I said, more or less, this:

"If my eyes do not disqualify me, sirs, then I don't think that there is anything in my intelligence or in my educational background that could possibly disqualify me. However, as I am certain you all know, it takes far more than intelligence and education to make a good officer. It takes initiative, courage, and a stability of character, which, to my regret, I don't think I possess. It is embarrassing to have to admit it, but if I lied on the subject in order to become an officer, the Army would discover the lie quickly enough."

They didn't ask me anything more, and I was relieved. I didn't want to be an officer under any conditions and that in itself was a character trait that disqualified me, so that my statement was true enough. I had phrased it in such a way, however, as to leave them flattered to ecstasy.

I left, hoping for the best.

And that same day, simply because of the work I was doing for Kriegman, I was promoted to corporal, got my stripes, and had them sewn on. After eight months and ten days as a buck private, I had become a noncommissioned officer!

While I was in town having my corporal's stripes sewed on, I met Gladys